

Special Topic Area – Industrial Base Research and Experimentation Events

BACKGROUND:

The Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) long-term, open call for new and novel technology solutions entitled the “Expedited Research Implementation Series” seeking solutions or capabilities that deliver breakthrough technological advancements. This Special Topic Area (STA) is a supplementary, limited period announcement to solicit, collect, and assess disruptive solutions, and make those solutions available through rapid acquisition pathways. This STA will be open for submissions from 1 May 2025 through 30 June 2025.

The ERIS Master Solicitation can be found here:

<https://sam.gov/opp/1e287185b7694348881c2d99dcf0e8bf/view>

WARNING: DO NOT SUBMIT VIA THIS PAGE: This Special Topic Opportunity Page provides the content requirements and instructions for your submission. The actual submission, however, will be made through the ERIS Marketplace located [here](https://www.darpaconnect.us/eris): <https://www.darpaconnect.us/eris>. After navigating to the ERIS Marketplace Page, click on the “Request ERIS Account” button to register for an ERIS account. Once registered, click on the “Access ERIS” button to begin the correct submission workflow.

SUBMISSION INSTRUCTIONS:

The submission process for this Special Topic consists of steps:

- **Step I** – Video pitch submission through the [ERIS Marketplace](#) Opportunity page.
- **Step II** – Video submissions are assessed in accordance with the specific assessment process and rubric provided below as Appendix (1).
 - o Submissions will only be accepted via the ERISs Marketplace located [here](#). After navigating to the ERISs Marketplace Page, click on the “Request ERIS Account” button to register for an ERIS account. Once registered, click on the “Access ERIS” button to begin the submission workflow.
 - o Submit your video pitch to the STA: “Industrial Base Research and Experimentation Events”
 - o To identify that your video submission is being submitted against the “Industrial Base Research and Experimentation Events” STA, the Title of your submission should start with “Industrial Base” and then continue with your company specific title (e.g., Industrial Base: Rapid Experimentation).

Content of the video submissions must adhere to the ERIS Marketplace guidelines and submission instructions in Section VII of the ERIS Master Program Solicitation, located [here](#). The ERIS submission checklist is available via the ERIS Marketplace website. Each submission must include:

(1) 7 minute pitch video

- Details provided on p. 3-5, section VII of the program solicitation.

(2) ERIS supplemental slides:

- Details provided on p. 5-6 section VII of the program solicitation.

(3) Submission form

- Details provided on p 3-5, section VII of the program solicitation.

Problem Statement:

Research and/or Event Design and Facilitation to Inform Scaling of the U.S. Industrial Base

The Adaptive Capabilities Office (ACO) bridges DARPA's advanced research and real-world application, accelerating the transition of groundbreaking technologies and providing strategic insights to prevent surprise and maintain technological advantage. ACO seeks organizations to support two complementary efforts:

- **Industrial base research** (basic, applied, and advanced research), and
- **Design and facilitation of stakeholder experimentation events** in support of industrial base research

Proposals may address either or both areas. Organizations specializing in one domain are encouraged to apply individually or partner with others.

Purpose

This initiative strengthens ACO's ability to conduct basic research (understanding systemic constraints), applied research (identifying actionable pathways to address constraints), and advanced research (developing tools and data models) to inform U.S. industrial base scaling efforts. Proposed work must surface real-world constraints and solutions across manufacturing, capital formation, supply chains, workforce, and regulatory policy through structured, analyzable outputs that integrate into broader modeling and various programs.

Areas of Interest

Area 1: Industrial Base Research

ACO seeks research teams to:+

- Illuminate systemic constraints, not just point solutions.
- Analyze dimensions like infrastructure, workforce, capital, and supply chains.
- Fuse disparate data into coherent throughput, cost, and cycle time assessments.
- Develop analytic tools, datasets, and insight products that advance the state of the art.
- Deliver raw and synthesized outputs compatible with ongoing ACO analytical efforts.

Area 2: Experimentation and Stakeholder Engagement Events

ACO seeks event design and facilitation teams to:

- Develop tailored engagements that identify actionable scaling constraints.
- Capture real-time, structured data using digital tools and sensemaking frameworks.
- Enable iterative hypothesis testing across multiple sessions.
- Generate decision-grade research inputs for immediate analysis and application.
- Strengthen cross-sector stakeholder alignment.

Event formats will range from half-day design sprints to multi-day stakeholder convenings. Examples include focus groups, workshops, modeling events, and concept mapping.

Continuation Criteria for Event-Based Work

For organizations facilitating stakeholder engagements, the following are expected to be discussed in ERIS submission:

- Delivery of a comprehensive event design package (run-of-show, toolkits, analytic methods).
- Real-time capture and synthesis of outputs (whiteboards, frameworks, participant ideation).
- Delivery of event data summaries, insights, and visualizations within 14 days post-event.
- Professional facilitation quality and responsiveness to participant feedback.

Continuation Criteria for Research-Based Work

For organizations conducting research, the following are expected to be discussed in the ERIS Submission:

- **Delivery of Actionable Research Outputs:** Timely submission of structured datasets, synthesis reports, and decision-grade insights that directly inform ACO's modeling, scenario analysis, or program planning efforts.
- **Demonstrated Advancement Beyond the State of the Art:** Clear evidence that research activities identify systemic constraints, and leverage novel analytical frameworks or tools that meaningfully advance understanding beyond traditional point solutions.
- **Integration into Iterative Research Cycles:** Demonstrated ability to adapt research hypotheses, models, and findings based on feedback, emerging data, and evolving ACO research needs, ensuring alignment with program objectives over time.

Additional Information

- **Responses for traditional research or workshop facilitation will not meet the criteria nor the intent of this effort.** Proposals must demonstrate rapid research and experimentation to achieve rapid, actionable insight generation.
- **The evaluation criteria is provided below as Appendix (1).** Changes from the ERIS Master Solicitation only reside in the weightings of the factors. There are no changes to the factors or factor descriptions.

Appendix (1): Special Topic Area – “Industrial Base Research and Experimentation Events” ERIS Evaluation Criteria

Factor	Factor Definition	Ratings / Rating Definitions				
		Unsatisfactory	Marginal	Satisfactory	Highly Satisfactory	Superior
Defining the Problem & Current State of the Art	Assessment of the degree to which the submission <i>clearly and comprehensively defines (1)</i> the scope of the problem(s) that the solution is/will be developed to address and (2) the current State of the Art within the field of potential solutions for the problem defined .	The submission does not clearly or comprehensively define the scope of the problem(s) that the solution is/will be developed to address. The submission does not clearly or comprehensively define the current State of the Art within the field of potential solutions for the problem defined.	The submission provides a somewhat clear and comprehensive definition of the scope of the problem(s) that the solution is/will be developed to address. The submission provides a somewhat clear and comprehensive definition of the current State of the Art within the field of potential solutions for the problem defined.	The submission provides an adequate level of clarity and comprehensiveness in its definition of the scope of the problem(s) that the solution is/will be developed to address. The submission provides an adequate level of clarity and comprehensiveness in its definition of the current State of the Art within the field of potential solutions for the problem defined.	The submission provides a very clear and comprehensive definition of the scope of the problem(s) that the solution is/will be developed to address. The submission provides a very clear and comprehensive definition of the State of the Art within the field of potential solutions for the problem defined.	The submission provides an exceptional level of clarity and comprehensiveness in its definition of the scope of the problem(s) that the solution is/will be developed to address. The submission provides an exceptional level of clarity and comprehensiveness in its definition of the current State of the Art within the field of potential solutions for the problem defined.
Weight: 30%	Points Possible: 30	5	15	20	25	30
Advancing the State of the Art	Assessment of the degree(s) to which the proposed solution, if successful, will advance the current state of the art within the solution's relevant field(s).	The submission, if successful, will not advance the current state of the art within the solution's relevant field(s).	The submission, if successful, will slightly advance the current state of the art within the solution's relevant field(s).	The submission, if successful, will adequately advance the current state of the art within the solution's relevant field(s).	The submission, if successful, will significantly advance the current state of the art within the solution's relevant field(s).	The submission, if successful, will exponentially advance and/or redefine state of the art within the solution's relevant field(s).
Weight: 40%	Points Possible: 40	8	16	24	32	40
Team Capability (Key Personnel Vision, Expertise, and Experience)	Assessment of capability of the proposing Team's key personnel to drive the proposed project to a successful outcome based on their vision, expertise, and experience.	The proposed team has not demonstrated that they are capable of driving the proposed project to a successful outcome based on the vision, expertise, and experience of its Key Personnel	The proposed team has demonstrated it is somewhat capable of driving the proposed project to a successful outcome based on the vision, expertise, and experience of its Key Personnel	The proposed team has demonstrated it is capable of driving the proposed project to a successful outcome based on the vision, expertise, and experience of its Key Personnel	The proposed team has demonstrated it is more than capable of driving the proposed project to a successful outcome based on the vision, expertise, and experience of its Key Personnel	The proposed team has demonstrated it is resoundingly capable of driving the proposed project to a successful outcome based on the vision, expertise, and experience of its Key Personnel
Weight: 25%	Points Possible: 25	5	10	15	20	25
Defense and/or Commercial Market Use Case/Impact	Assessment of the proposed solution impact to current commercial and/or defense use cases.	The proposed solution has not demonstrated an impact to defense/commercial market(s) or viable defense/commercial application(s).	The proposed solution has demonstrated a marginal impact to defense/commercial market(s) or somewhat viable defense/commercial application(s).	The proposed solution has sufficiently demonstrated an impact to defense/commercial market(s) or viable defense/commercial application(s).	The proposed solution has demonstrated a significant impact to defense/commercial market(s) or significant defense/commercial application(s).	The proposed solution has demonstrated an exceptional impact to defense/commercial market(s) or exceptional defense/commercial application(s).
Weight: 5%	Points Possible: 5	1	2	3	4	5